



Aardling brand guide

Version 1.0.0-beta.3

Software strategy, architecture, and domain modelling in complex environments.

Where to find things

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Each section maps to a file in the package's **guidelines/** directory, named in the top right of every page. Where this printed guide condenses, that file is the longer answer — and where the two disagree, the file wins.

What this is

Everything Aardling puts in front of a reader is built from one package. This document is that package, printed.

The rules here are not preferences. Each was decided against something measured — a contrast ratio, a rendered mark at 16px, a heading at half a gradient's width. Where this guide states a number, the number came from a test.

Follow it when you are asked to make an exception. The exceptions that exist are already in here; the ones that are not in here are not exceptions.

Getting the package into a project

Published to GitHub Packages, not the public registry — one extra step before install works like any other package.

```
@aardling:registry=https://npm.pkg.github.com  
//npm.pkg.github.com/:_authToken=${GITHUB_TOKEN}
```

In the consuming project's `.npmrc`, committed — it names the registry, not the secret. The token is a classic personal access token scoped to `read:packages` and `repo`.

```
npm install @aardling/brand-aardling
```

Using it in a project

```
@import "@aardling/brand-aardling/assets/fonts/fonts.css";  
@import "@aardling/brand-aardling/tokens/tokens.css";
```

Every colour, typeface and spacing step in this guide, as a CSS custom property or read from `tokens/tokens.json` — enough to build anything carrying the brand: a web page, a deck, a one-off document, with the logos and icons in `assets/` alongside. An agent reads the rules directly: copy or symlink `skills/aardling-brand` into `.claude/skills/`.

Aardling

Capital A, the rest lower case, one word. There is no second accepted form.

In headlines, in body copy, in navigation, in email, in decks, in social posts, and in a sentence that begins with it. In prose, never *aardling*, never **AARDLING**, never *AardLing*.

Machine identifiers stay lower case

npm does not accept a capital in a scope, and mixed-case paths break on case-sensitive filesystems. The spelling rule governs words a reader sees set as text; it does not govern identifiers.

@aardling/brand-aardling
aardling/ aardling-brand --
colour-* aardling.eu

The logotype is drawn, not spelled

The mark sets AARDLING in capitals with the double-A ligature. That is lettering. It is not permission to set the name in capitals anywhere else — not in a heading, not in a navigation item, not in a slide title.

The mark and the word are not the same thing

The mark on the left is a drawing. The word beside it is text. A slide that carries both carries **AARDLING** once, as artwork, and **Aardling** everywhere the reader reads.

The brand name stands alone

Four legal entities exist. Use one only where the law or an accountant needs it: an imprint, a contract, an invoice, terms and conditions, a privacy policy, a VAT line. An entity name never appears in a headline, a deck, a byline or body copy.

YES

Aardling ran the
modelling workshop.

NO

Aardling BV ran the
modelling workshop.

Registered addresses

Canonical. Transcribe the street lines exactly. Place names take their English form where one exists, which is why these read Antwerp and not Antwerpen; Hoorn and Lille have none and are unchanged. Aardling BV and Aardling Belgium BV share a building and differ only by bus number.

Aardling BV

Tabakvest 87 bus 4761
2000 Antwerp
Belgium

Aardling Belgium BV

Tabakvest 87 bus 4762
2000 Antwerp
Belgium

Aardling Netherlands BV

DTG Accountants
Postbus 2131
1620 EC Hoorn
Netherlands

Aardling France SAS

10 Rue Michel Servet
59000 Lille
France

An address appears only where an entity name does. Registration and VAT numbers are not carried in the package: take those from the register or from finance.

Seven brand colours

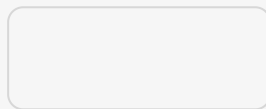
The brand colours come from the original brand guide. A functional set, five colours the brand guide never approved, sits on the next page — each earns its place doing a job these seven cannot.

BRAND



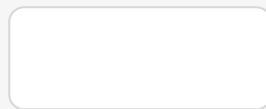
Night Blue

#181C2F



Snow White

#F6F6F6



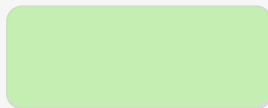
White

#FFFFFF



Violet

#B9BBF4



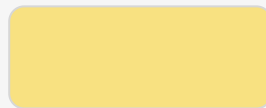
Lime Green

#C5EEB3



Ocean Blue

#4B7BC3



Yellow

#F8E181



Pink

#F3B0B0

White is not in the original guide. It is listed because cards and panels sit on it, and a ground that carries text has to be an approved half of a pair.

Five functional colours

These were in the website's CSS without ever having been approved, and are kept because each does a job the seven brand colours cannot.

**Hover Green**

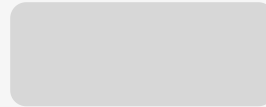
#98DE7E

The hover and focus state of the primary button.

**Muted Grey**

#6B6B6B

Secondary text, and the boundary of a form control.

**Hairline Grey**

#D7D7D7

Hairline rules. Never a control boundary; it does not measure.

**Error Red**

#CF1322

Form error messages.

**Success Green**

#38761E

Confirmation messages.

Muted Grey is set where it clears 4.5:1 on both White and Snow White; a lighter grey does not, however good it looks. Success Green sits at hue 102, between Lime Green and Hover Green — the brand's own green darkened until it reads as text — and was set to land on Error Red's numbers, so a confirmation and a rejection carry the same weight. The original guide states CMYK values alongside each colour, but they do not match a standard conversion from the same hex and name no profile, so they are not reproduced — get CMYK from your printer against a named profile.

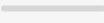
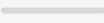
Colours are approved in pairs

A pair not in this table is not approved. Each sample is the pair itself.

Pair	Foreground on background	Ratio	Use for
Aa	Night Blue on Snow White	15.60	Page ground and all long-form reading.
Aa	Night Blue on White	16.85	Cards and panels lifted off the ground.
Aa	Snow White on Night Blue	15.60	Inverted sections, the footer, dark buttons.
Aa	Night Blue on Lime Green	13.05	The primary button.
Aa	Night Blue on Hover Green	10.50	The primary button, hover and focus.
Aa	Night Blue on Yellow	12.90	Section grounds and cards.
Aa	Night Blue on Pink	9.35	Section grounds and cards.
Aa	Night Blue on Violet	9.21	Section grounds and callouts.
Aa	Muted Grey on White	5.33	Secondary text, and a control border, on a card.
Aa	Muted Grey on Snow White	4.93	The same, on the page ground.

More approved pairs

Continued from the previous page. A pair not in either table is not approved.

Pair	Foreground on background	Ratio	Use for
 Aa	Error Red on White	5.57	Form error messages on a card.
 Aa	Error Red on Snow White	5.16	Form error messages on the page ground.
 Aa	Success Green on White	5.56	Confirmation messages on a card.
 Aa	Success Green on Snow White	5.14	Confirmation messages on the page ground.
 Aa	Ocean Blue on White	4.27	Display text at 24px and above. Never body text.
 Aa	Ocean Blue on Snow White	3.95	The same, on the page ground.
	Hairline Grey on White	1.44	Hairline rules only. Never text.
	Hairline Grey on Snow White	1.33	The same, on the page ground.

The palette names colours; roles name jobs

A component references the job, never the colour, and a theme re-points the jobs without the palette moving at all. `--colour-snow-white` is Snow White in every theme; `--text-primary` is Night Blue on a light ground and Snow White on a dark one. In a stylesheet, write the role.

Role	Light	Dark
<code>--surface-page</code>	Snow White	Night Blue
<code>--surface-raised</code>	White	Dark Surface
<code>--text-primary</code>	Night Blue	Snow White
<code>--text-secondary</code>	Muted Grey	Dark Muted Grey
<code>--text-error</code>	Error Red	Dark Error Red
<code>--text-success</code>	Success Green	Dark Success Green
<code>--border-control</code>	Muted Grey	Dark Muted Grey
<code>--border-hairline</code>	Hairline Grey	Dark Hairline Grey
<code>--focus-ring</code>	Night Blue	Snow White
<code>--link-underline</code>	Night Blue at 50%	Snow White at 50%

Ten roles, and no more without a reason. An eleventh role is a request to add a colour, and goes through the same approval as one. Status is a pair: `--text-error` for what went wrong, `--text-success` for what passed. The tenth is the one role that is not a palette colour: `--link-underline` is `--text-primary` at half strength, the link underline at rest, kept translucent so it sits at half strength on a raised surface too.

Five more colours for the dark ground

Nothing in the light functional set crosses over to a dark ground. These five exist because none of it reads there.

**Dark Surface**

#242942

Cards and panels lifted off the dark ground.

**Dark Muted Grey**

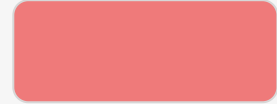
#9BA1B8

Secondary text, and the boundary of a form control.

**Dark Hairline Grey**

#3A4059

Hairline rules. Never a control boundary.

**Dark Error Red**

#EF7A7A

Form error messages.

**Dark Success Green**

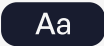
#5AB234

Confirmation messages.

Muted Grey measures 3.16 on Night Blue and is too faint to read; Hairline Grey measures 11.71, far too loud for a hairline; and Error Red and Success Green both measure 3.03 — the same number by coincidence — below what a message has to clear. That is the whole reason these five exist.

Night Blue is the dark ground

Snow White on Night Blue is a pair this brand has always had — it is what an inverted section and the footer are already made of. The rest of the interface needed somewhere to go.

Pair	Foreground on background	Ratio	Use for
 Aa	Snow White on Night Blue	15.60	The dark page ground. All long-form reading.
 Aa	Snow White on Dark Surface	13.21	Cards and panels lifted off the dark ground.
 Aa	Dark Muted Grey on Night Blue	6.57	Secondary text, and control boundaries.
 Aa	Dark Muted Grey on Dark Surface	5.56	The same, on a card.
 Aa	Dark Error Red on Night Blue	6.21	Form error messages.
 Aa	Dark Error Red on Dark Surface	5.26	The same, on a card.
 Aa	Dark Success Green on Night Blue	6.30	Confirmation messages.
 Aa	Dark Success Green on Dark Surface	5.34	The same, on a card.
	Dark Hairline Grey on Night Blue	1.65	Hairline rules only. Never text.
	Dark Hairline Grey on Dark Surface	1.40	The same, on a card.
 Aa	Ocean Blue on Night Blue	3.95	Display text at 24px and above. Never body text.

Dark Surface on Night Blue is 1.18. That is a surface against a surface, not a text pair, and it is enough to separate two grounds when a radius separates them too — but not enough to be the only cue that a card exists. Give the card padding as well.

The pastels do not change

Violet, Lime Green, Yellow and Pink are grounds, and the only foreground approved on any of them is Night Blue. That pair measures the same on a dark page as on a light one — 9.21 to 13.05 — so a pastel section is identical in both themes, and so is the primary button. They are light panels on a dark page, and that is correct rather than a compromise. A focus ring inside one is Night Blue, not Snow White.

Not every approved pair carries a mark

Nine of the eighteen light pairs are also approved for the logotype and the icon logo. A pair approved for secondary text, form errors, confirmations or hairline rules is approved for that, and a mark is none of those things. No mark is approved on Dark Surface: a mark on a dark card takes the Night Blue ground it already has a lockup for. The nine are in the Logos section, from page 21.

Five things the palette does not do

Ocean Blue as body text

4.27:1 on White, 3.95:1 on Snow White, 3.95:1 on Night Blue. It is a details colour in either theme: large display text, icons and rules. The website uses it as the link hover colour at 18px, which fails — a link never changes colour on hover, and the underline carries the change instead.

Ocean Blue as a background

Night Blue on it is 3.95:1 and Snow White on it is 3.95:1. There is no readable text colour for that ground, so it is never a ground.

The four pastels as text

Violet, Lime Green, Yellow and Pink are grounds and details. Night Blue is the only foreground approved on any of them, in either theme. Pink is close enough to a light red to tempt as the dark error colour, and Lime Green close enough to a light green to tempt as the success colour. Neither is text.

Either green on the wrong ground

Success Green measures 3.03 on Night Blue and 2.57 on Dark Surface; Dark Success Green measures 2.67 on White and 2.47 on Snow White. Neither is a background either — a confirmation sits on the surface it is already on.

Any pair not in the tables

Including pastel on pastel, and any of the greys on a pastel.

Two faces, used in very unequal measure

DISPLAY

Voyage

--font-display: Voyage, Georgia, "Times New Roman", serif. Regular only — no italic, no variable axis, one weight. Below about 24px it loses its detail and reads as a generic serif, so it never sets anything small.

BODY

General Sans

--font-body: "General Sans", "Helvetica Neue", Helvetica, Arial, sans-serif. A variable font: one file per style spanning weight 200 to 700, upright and italic.

Both faces ship in the package as woff2 and are self-hosted. Never a link or an import to Google Fonts, Fontshare or any other third-party host: Aardling's typography does not depend on a network it does not control.

Letter-spacing

None, at any size, in either face, with one exception: uppercase labels take 0.12em to 0.14em, because capitals set at their default fit are too tight to read. The eyebrow at the top of this page is one.

Wrapping

Headings, taglines, pull quotes, buttons and captions are balanced across their lines rather than left with a single orphaned word. Body copy is set to avoid orphans. Protected terms never break — see the Layout section, from page 29.

Six weights, upright and italic

General Sans covers 200 to 700 in one variable file per style, so every weight below is available without loading a file per cut. Voyage is Regular only.

200 Extralight	Very large display settings only
300 Light	Large introductory paragraphs
400 Regular	Body copy, buttons, captions — the default
500 Medium	Headings, everywhere
600 Semibold	Emphasis in running text, table headers
700 Bold	Rare — only where 600 fails to separate

Headings are **500**. Use `--font-weight-heading` rather than the literal, so the decision lives in one place. The website's stylesheet has asked for 500 since it was built and silently rendered 400, because only two cuts were loaded; the Medium cut is in the package now and the original intent stands.

Italics

400 Regular italic	<i>The title of a work</i>
500 Medium italic	<i>A term being introduced</i>
600 Semibold italic	<i>A genuine aside</i>

Italics exist at every weight. Use them for what italics are for. Not for emphasis; that is what 600 is for.

Eight steps, and the base is the phone

The sizes declared in **:root** are what a 360px screen gets, shown here at size. Every larger step is a **min-width** query layered on top — the direction is set out in the Web section, from page 33.

h1 36 / 1.2	Aardling
h2 30 / 1.2	Aardling
h3 26 / 1.2	Aardling
h4 22 / 1.2	Aardling
h5 20 / 1.2	Aardling
h6 18 / 1.3	Aardling
body 18 / 1.5	Aardling
small 14 / 1.5	Aardling

The scale moves at four breakpoints

Step	Phone	From 540	From 960	From 1728	From 1920
h1	36	44	55	61	66
h2	30	36	45	50	54
h3	26	28	35	39	42
h4	22	24	30	33	36
h5	20	20	25	28	30
h6	18	18	22	24	26
body	18	18	18	20	22
small	14	14	14	15	17

The 540px step moves h1 to h4 and nothing else: further down, the phone sizes are already right, and dropping h6 below 18 would push it under the body size it has to outrank. There is no multiplier — the columns were set by eye, not by scaling the one beside them. This page is set at the 540 column, because an A4 sheet at 96dpi is 794px wide.

Voyage holds a phrase, not a paragraph

Voyage is used sparingly — typically once on a page, on one short title. Normally that is the h1: the page hero, or the one heading a reader is meant to carry away. A second Voyage setting on the same page is an exception and needs a reason.

Everything else is General Sans, including headings that look like they want the display face: h2 and h3, card titles, call-to-action headings, pull quotes, form section labels, table captions, sidebar headers. A page set almost entirely in General Sans is the normal case, not a compromise.

Keep the Voyage title short — one line, a handful of words. The face has one weight, no italic and no variable axis. Below about 24px it never sets anything at all: if a title needs to be smaller than that, it is not the Voyage title on that page.

Voyage never sets a heading on artwork

A heading placed on a gradient is General Sans at the heading weight, whatever its size. Voyage's hairlines and its thick-to-thin contrast are exactly what the gradients' grain interferes with. It is the same interference that sets the marks' minimum sizes on a gradient. See the Imagery section, from page 24.

Every Voyage setting in this document is a page title, one per page — the single exception being the specimen on page 16, which is the face shown as itself. The subheads, the tables and this paragraph are all General Sans.

Two marks, one measure of air

The logotype is 623 × 131 units; the icon logo is 167 × 107. Both are transparent and filled with **currentColor** — set **color** on the parent and the mark follows. The icon logo is the double-A ligature cut from the logotype's own outline, and it sits inside the logotype at 1:1.

Clear space on all four sides is the height of the icon logo: 106 units



That measure is not arbitrary and it is not two measures. The icon logo's ink is 106.25 units tall in both drawings, so one number serves both marks. On the logotype, 106 units is 81% of the mark's own height. That is deliberate: cramped is the failure that keeps happening, and nobody has ever complained that an Ardling mark had too much room.

Mark	Mark size	Lockup canvas
Logotype	623 × 131	835 × 343
Icon logo	167 × 107	379 × 379

The icon canvas is squared so one file serves an avatar upload without recropping. Squaring only adds air: the horizontal clear space is exactly 106, the vertical 136. Lockups — the mark, its ground and its clear space flattened into one fixed-size file — are for the places that cannot supply a ground or set **color**. They are generated from the two masters and never edited by hand.

The floors, shown at size

AARDLING

Logotype: 96px mark, 129px lockup



Icon logo: 16px mark, 36px lockup

Mark	On a flat ground	On a gradient
Logotype	96px mark, 129px lockup	380px lockup
Icon logo	16px mark, 36px lockup	64px lockup

A gradient costs roughly three times the floor a flat ground does, and the reason is the grain rather than the contrast. Below those widths, use a flat approved ground.

Ocean Blue needs more room than the rest

The palette allows Ocean Blue for display text at 24px and above. The logotype's cap height is 106 of its 131 units, so a 96px-wide logotype has a 16px cap — under that threshold. The two rules would contradict each other if left alone.

An Ocean Blue logotype is never narrower than 141px, a 189px lockup. That is the width at which its cap height reaches 24px. It is not drawn on the icon logo at all, which floors at 16px and never gets near.

This is the one colourway whose minimum differs from the mark's own. Ocean Blue is a details colour and the logotype is drawn in hairlines; 4.27:1 on White behaves worse than the number suggests when the strokes are that thin.

The logotype is for big touchpoints — a site header, a slide, a social post, anywhere the name should be read. The icon logo is for small ones — a favicon, an avatar, a thumbnail — and for anywhere the logotype would be illegible.

Nine colourways

Both marks take all nine, except the two Ocean Blue pairs, which are the logotype only. Shown at 170px; each chip's padding is the mark's own clear space.

Night Blue on Snow White

Night Blue on White

Snow White on Night Blue

Night Blue on Lime Green

Night Blue on Yellow

Night Blue on Pink

Night Blue on Violet

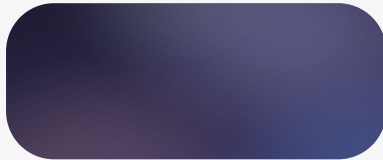
Ocean Blue on White — logotype only, never under 141px

Ocean Blue on Snow White — logotype only, never under 141px

The other seven approved pairs carry no mark. A greyed mark reads as disabled, a red one as a failure, a Hairline Grey one is invisible at 1.44:1, and a mark has no hover state.

Four gradients

SVG, a few kilobytes each, sharp at any size. Two dark, two light. Each is authored at 1600 × 1000 and crops to fill any box without distorting.



Vesper

Near-black to a deep violet, a Pink glow low left, Ocean Blue holding the far corner. The quiet dark one: behind a slide of content, or a section band that must not compete. **No grain** — with it, white falls from 6.57:1 to 5.20:1.



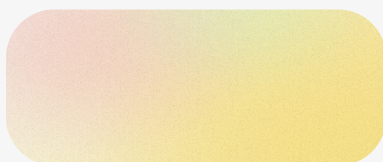
Understory

The darkest field in the brand: Ocean Blue at one corner, Lime Green at the other, near-black between them. The dark one meant to be looked at — a cover, or a full-bleed ground. It competes, deliberately. **No grain:** with it, white drops to 4.60:1, under the floor.



Bloom

Snow White into Violet, with Lime Green and Pink blooms. The light option, and the only one that takes Night Blue text-adjacent panels well. Carries grain, drawn as an SVG filter rather than a baked-in texture.



Harvest

Snow White into Yellow, with a second Yellow bloom low, Pink opposite, and a Lime Green highlight. The warm option: social cards, event artwork, a title slide. Carries grain.

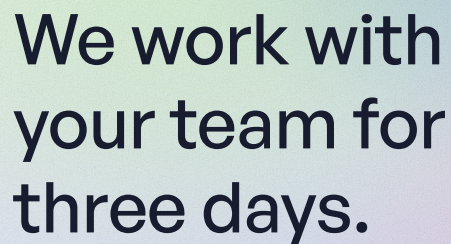
Each one sits at one end of the luminance range, and stays there. That is what lets a single knocked-out colour separate cleanly from the whole field rather than only from part of it. A gradient whose ramp spans the range takes no mark at all, and the warm gradient that preceded Harvest was withdrawn for exactly that reason.

They are **artwork, not colour**. Never sample a pixel into the palette and never recolour one ad hoc — a new colourway gets drawn and added.

A mark, or one heading. Never both.



Either mark, knocked out: White on Vesper and Understory, Night Blue on Bloom and Harvest. Measured under the mark's own ink — Vesper 7.09:1 at worst, Understory 7.00:1, Bloom 8.08:1, Harvest 10.33:1.



Or one heading, in the same colour the knocked-out mark takes on that ground, so a gradient never carries two lettering colours.

Constraint	Why
The body face, never Voyage.	Voyage's thick-to-thin contrast and hairline serifs lose to the grain.
35px or larger.	Comfortably past the large-text threshold, with margin for the grain.
At most half the width, on the gradient's steadiest side — upper right on Vesper, lower left on Understory, right of centre on Bloom, lower right on Harvest.	Full width across the middle, a heading runs 6.65:1 to 16.25:1 on Vesper and 5.87:1 to 17.33:1 on Understory, and visibly shifts weight along the line. Inside the steady region it swings 2.91 and 3.88. Width alone is not enough: Understory's right half still swings 10.41.
Two or three lines, balanced.	A heading is a phrase held inside one region of the artwork, not a line crossing it.

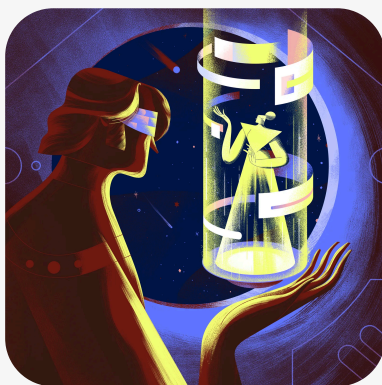
Nothing else goes on top. No body copy, no captions, no labels, no lists, no buttons — and no scrim or blur anywhere, on anything.

Illustrations take no text at all

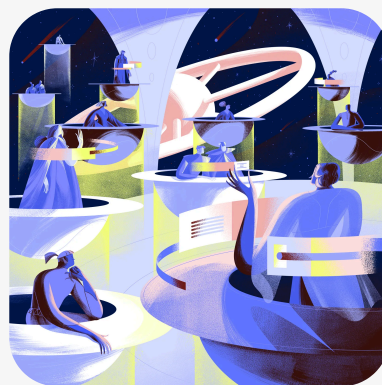
Not a heading, not a caption. The licence on the previous page is for gradients only, because a gradient is a controlled field with a measured luminance band and an illustration is not. Text goes beside an illustration, or on a solid panel next to it.



A workshop in progress



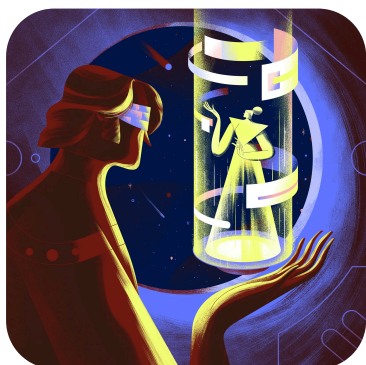
One-to-one coaching



A conference or event

These are painterly and stay raster — the exception the SVG-by-default rule exists for. The package ships them at 1600px as WebP with a PNG beside each.

YES — TEXT BESIDE THE IMAGE



One-to-one coaching

The image keeps its own frame and the words keep theirs. Nothing is set over the artwork, and nothing needs a scrim to stay readable. The alternatives, in order of preference: text beside the image; text on a solid panel adjacent to it; the image reduced to an accent.

The full-resolution masters — 5000 × 5000, plus CMYK TIFFs for print — are in the **Aardling — Brand** shared Google Drive. The package carries the versions meant for building things; Drive carries the originals.

No image beats a fake one

Some content doesn't have one yet. The easy fix — a flat background with the title set as text — is not an image but a placeholder that shipped. **Find a real one first:** a case study usually has one on the client's own site or press kit, and that beats anything drawn here.

WHEN NO SUITABLE PHOTOGRAPH EXISTS, IN THIS ORDER

CASE

Pricing the experts could read

Meridian Bank · 2026

1 • No image. The page renders correctly without one.



CASE

Pricing the experts could read

Meridian Bank · 2026

2 • A brand illustration.

Whichever reads closest to the content.

Pricing the experts could read

CASE

Meridian Bank · 2026

3 • A generated cover. The title on a gradient — and no title below it.

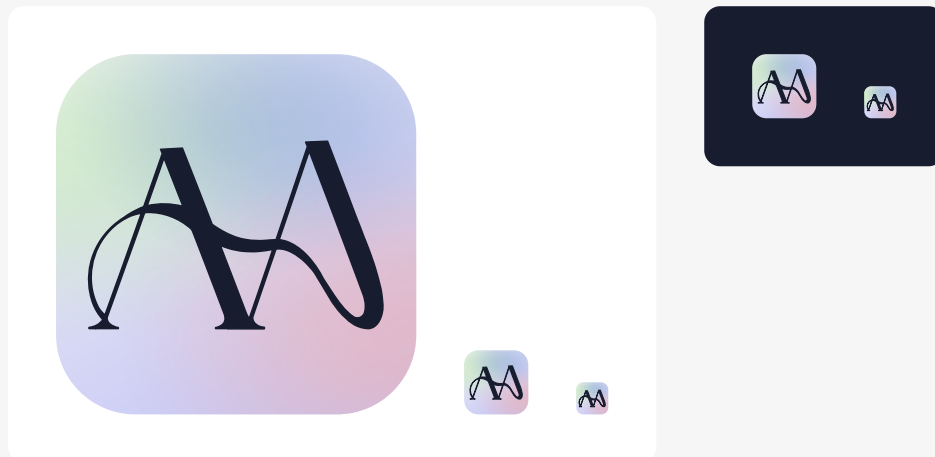
Reach for the plainer option first, and use the cover only when the title genuinely needs to carry the piece. The cover specimen above is reduced to fit three cards on one page; on a real card the heading holds the 35px floor the gradient licence sets.

The card drops its own title when its media is a cover

The heading on the gradient already *is* the title; setting it again below repeats the same words back to the reader — which is why the third card carries an eyebrow and metadata under the media, and no title line. Those stay: they carry what the cover doesn't. And nothing but the title goes on the artwork — no subtitle, no eyebrow, no metadata knocked out alongside it.

The icon logo, knocked out of Bloom

Night Blue on a rounded tile cut from **gradient-bloom.svg**. **favicon.svg** is the source; every raster is generated from it. Shown at 180, 32 and 16 pixels, on both grounds a tab strip offers.



Decision	Value	Why
Crop	The gradient's own centre square	No bespoke framing. A tighter crop raises contrast but lands in the Lime Green bloom, and the tile goes mint.
Corner radius	22% of the tile	The radius tokens are absolute and do not transfer to a drawing rendered from 16 to 512px. 22% is what iOS, Android and macOS use.
Mark size	82% of the tile width	At 74% the hairlines fall below one pixel at 16px and drop out.
Mark stroke	0.8 units, in the mark's own colour	Thickens the hairlines symmetrically without redrawing the letterform.

The favicon drops Bloom's grain. Below about 64px the filter is sampled far under its own frequency and lands as coloured blotch fighting the mark. That licence is narrow: a generated derivative at fixed small sizes is not a reproduction of the gradient, and Bloom and Harvest keep their grain wherever they are shown as themselves.

A favicon change ships the whole set: **favicon.svg**, **favicon.ico** with 16 and 32 embedded, **apple-touch-icon.png** at 180, **icon-192.png** and **icon-512.png**.

Spacing is specified, never implied

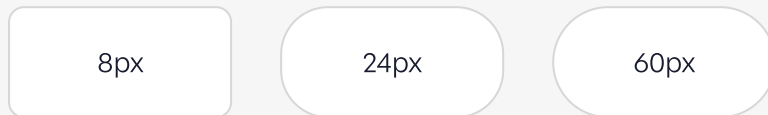
The scale is 8px steps. Nine are published, every one has a job, and each is shown here at size.

--space-1	8px	
--space-2	16px	
--space-3	24px	
--space-4	32px	
--space-6	48px	
--space-8	64px	
--space-10	80px	
--space-12	96px	
--space-18	144px	

--space-1	Gap inside a control: between an icon and its label.
--space-2	Gap between closely related things: a label and its field, items in a list.
--space-3	Grid gutter up to 1400px. Paragraph rhythm in running prose.
--space-4	Grid gutter above 1400px. Padding inside a card.
--space-6	Vertical padding of a coloured section, below 720px.
--space-8	Top and bottom of a hero, below 960px.
--space-10	Vertical padding of a coloured section, from 720px.
--space-12	Vertical padding of a coloured section, from 960px.
--space-18	Top of a detail-page hero, from 960px.

Prefer the larger step when two look plausible. Lay sibling groups out with flex or grid and gap — not margins on children, and not whitespace in the source.

Three radii, and no more



--radius-sm for tooltips, tags and swatches; **--radius-md** for cards, panels and image containers; **--radius-pill** for buttons and pills.

The button



--space-1 gap, 12px vertical and 24px horizontal padding, pill radius, never less than 44px high — a minimum for anything tappable, not a target to design down to.

Breakpoints and containers

Step	Breakpoint	Container
sm	540px	516px
md	720px	696px
lg	960px	936px
xxl	1400px	1312px
xxxl	1728px	1504px
mega	1920px	1696px

Page side margins are **--page-margin** — 28px — below 540px, and the container above it. 28px is the one published value in this brand that is not on the 8px ladder; it is inherited from the website and kept so that nothing reflows. **xl** at 1140px was declared and never used by anything, so it and its container are retired. Every query is **min-width**: the Web section, from page 33, lists the six that remain and says what each one moves.

A protected term sits on one line

Every break opportunity inside it is suppressed, at spaces and at hyphens alike. "Domain-Driven Design" is one concept and has to look like one.

NO

**Scaling Domain-
Driven Design to 800
engineers**

YES

**Scaling
Domain-Driven Design
to 800 engineers**

Domain-Driven Design · EventStorming · Event Sourcing · Team Topologies ·
Data Mesh · Aardling

In markup, wrap the whole term in a single span with **white-space: nowrap** — one span covers the spaces and the hyphens at once. In plain text, use a non-breaking space between the words *and* a non-breaking hyphen, but prefer the span wherever markup exists: U+2011 is missing from many fonts, Voyage included. If a term does not fit the line, the line is wrong, not the term.

Never text on top of an image

Not over photographs, not over illustrations, and not with a scrim, a blur or a gradient overlay to rescue it. The alternatives, in order of preference: text beside the image; text on a solid panel adjacent to it; the image reduced to an accent.

The current website breaks this — the default hero sets the h1 over a cover photograph — and so do several mockups in the original brand guide. Those layouts are wrong and change; the rule does not bend for them.

The single exception is the gradient licence in the Imagery section, from page 24, and it is narrow: a gradient is a measured field, an illustration is not.

The base value is the phone

Everything **tokens.css** declares in **:root** — type sizes, spacing, containers, the page margin — is what a 360px screen gets. Every media query in this brand is **min-width**, and each one restates only what actually changes at that width.

This is a reversal. Until version 0.8.0 **:root** held the desktop sizes and a **max-width** query shrank them, which described the phone as a subtraction from a screen nobody was designing on. The values did not change; the direction did.

Six breakpoints, each with a reason

Token	Value	What changes there
--breakpoint-sm	540px	h1 to h4 step up from the phone column. The page margin gives way to the container.
--breakpoint-md	720px	Vertical section padding goes from --space-6 to --space-10.
--breakpoint-lg	960px	The full desktop type scale. Section padding to --space-12.
--breakpoint-xxl	1400px	Grid gutter goes from --space-3 to --space-4.
--breakpoint-xxxl	1728px	Display step. The type scale rises, body to 20px. No layout change.
--breakpoint-mega	1920px	Display step. Type rises again, body to 22px. No layout change.

The last two are **display steps**: they exist so a 27-inch monitor does not set 18px body copy across a wide column. They move type and nothing else. **1140px** was declared and never used by anything; it and its container are retired.

Two rules that follow from it

Design at 360px first

Not 375, not 390. 360px is the narrowest width in common use, and a layout that survives it survives the rest. Check the hero, the navigation and any table at that width before opening a desktop viewport.

A custom property cannot be read in a media query

`@media (min-width: var(--breakpoint-lg))` does not work in any browser, and fails silently. The breakpoint tokens exist to be read from JavaScript and to keep the two token files in step — not to be used in a query. In a query, write the literal.

Focus is a requirement; hover is a courtesy

Anything that reacts to a pointer reacts to the keyboard the same way. Hover is the one state a touchscreen cannot produce at all, so no information, no control and no navigation may live in a hover state alone.

The ring is the same everywhere



Three pixels solid, offset two, on **:focus-visible** — so it appears for a keyboard and not under a mouse click. Night Blue on every light ground, Snow White on every dark one. Night Blue is the only palette colour that clears 3:1 against all eight approved grounds; Ocean Blue fails on Violet at 2.33, Pink at 2.37 and Hover Green at 2.66. Never **outline: none** without a replacement in the same rule.

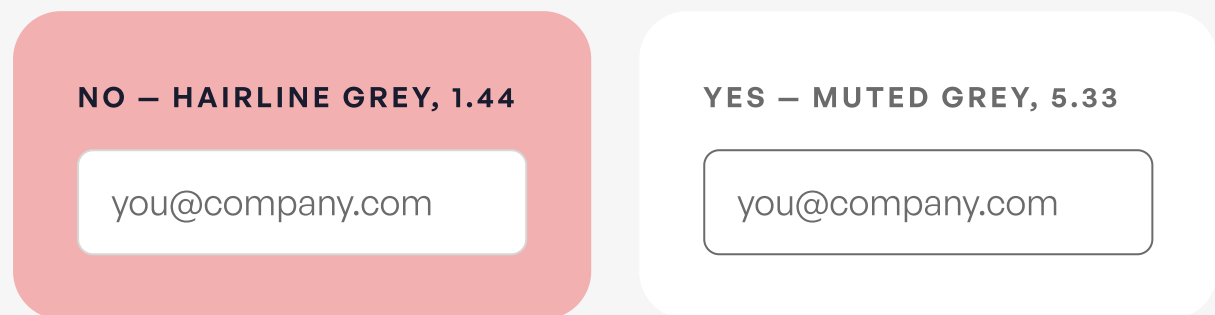
A link is underlined, always

There is no approved second text colour on the page ground, so the underline is not decoration — it is the only thing distinguishing a link, and removing it removes the link. Colour never changes on hover, at any size; the underline stays 1px and brightens from **--link-underline**, a 50% tint, to full colour.

We ran a three-day modelling workshop with their platform team, and it brightens on hover.

Visited links are not styled: there is no approved pair for a third text colour, and on a site of this kind the distinction tells a reader nothing they need.

A control boundary has to be visible



WCAG 1.4.11 holds a user-interface component boundary to 3:1. Hairline Grey measures 1.44 on White and 1.33 on Snow White: it rules a section off, and never borders a control. An error always carries a message saying what went wrong — never colour alone.

Two durations, two shadows

Motion

<code>--duration-fast</code>	120ms	Colour changes: hover, focus, active. Anything that does not move.
<code>--duration-base</code>	240ms	Anything that moves, resizes or fades — a disclosure, a drawer, a menu.
<code>--ease-standard</code>	cubic-bezier(0.2, 0, 0, 1) — every transition, both durations.	

One easing curve everywhere is what makes unrelated components feel like one site. The tokens collapse to 1ms under **prefers-reduced-motion**, so a transition written against them already complies; anything animating *without* them must be stopped by hand. Nothing animates on load — the page arrives at rest. Animate **transform** and **opacity**, nothing else.

Elevation

`--shadow-raised`

A card or panel at rest.

`--shadow-overlay`

A menu, a dialog, a sticky bar.

Both are cast in Night Blue rather than black — a neutral black shadow over a warm ground reads as dirt rather than depth. Two steps and no more: a third is a request for a hierarchy the page does not have. On the dark ground `--shadow-raised` is **none**, because a shadow under a dark card on a dark page is invisible and the surface colour does that job instead.

Four icon sizes

<code>--icon-sm</code>	16px	Inline with small text, and inside dense controls.
<code>--icon-md</code>	20px	Inline with body copy. The default.
<code>--icon-lg</code>	24px	Buttons, navigation items, list bullets. The largest step there is.

Set the height and let the width follow. Several marks are not square, so constraining the width distorts them. The set is not drawn on a common grid — some marks carry interface-scale dimensions at a 1.25 stroke, the rest are viewBox-only at drawing scale with a stroke of 2 — so at the same pixel height they will not have the same apparent weight. These sizes are a starting point; match the icon to its neighbouring text by eye.

The reader's operating system decides

One **prefers-color-scheme: dark** block re-points the eight roles, and that is the whole mechanism. There is no toggle in the header, nothing to remember between visits, and no third state to test.

The palette does not move. **--colour-snow-white** is Snow White in both themes; it is **--text-primary** that resolves differently. A component written against roles is already correct in dark mode and needs no dark-mode CSS of its own. A component written against palette colours is the bug.

Domain Modelling

Untangle complex business domains and make your architecture work for you. Secondary text sits at 6.57, a hairline at 1.65, and a card lifts to **#242942** rather than casting a shadow.

Book a call

Focused

The pastels do not change

Violet, Lime Green, Yellow and Pink are grounds whose only approved foreground is Night Blue, and that pair measures the same on a dark page as a light one. A pastel section is identical in both themes, and so is the primary button. They are light panels on a dark page, and that is correct rather than a compromise.

A light island says so

A pastel section on a dark page carries **data-surface="light"**, which puts all ten roles back. Without it a focus ring inside this callout would inherit Snow White and measure 1.69 against the Violet — invisible. An inverted section is the mirror of it: **data-surface="dark"**, which is what the footer uses.

light and **dark** are the only two values, and **data-surface** is the only attribute this brand styles. Artwork has no dark variant: the four gradients and the illustrations are the same files in both themes. Check both before calling anything finished, by switching the operating system setting — a browser devtools override misses the scoped case entirely.

A hero is text on flat ground

Four components, all built from tokens that already exist. The hero is the first: what a page is, in one heading, never on artwork.

WORKSHOPS

Three days, and a model your team can use

We run EventStorming with the people who already know the business.

Book a workshop

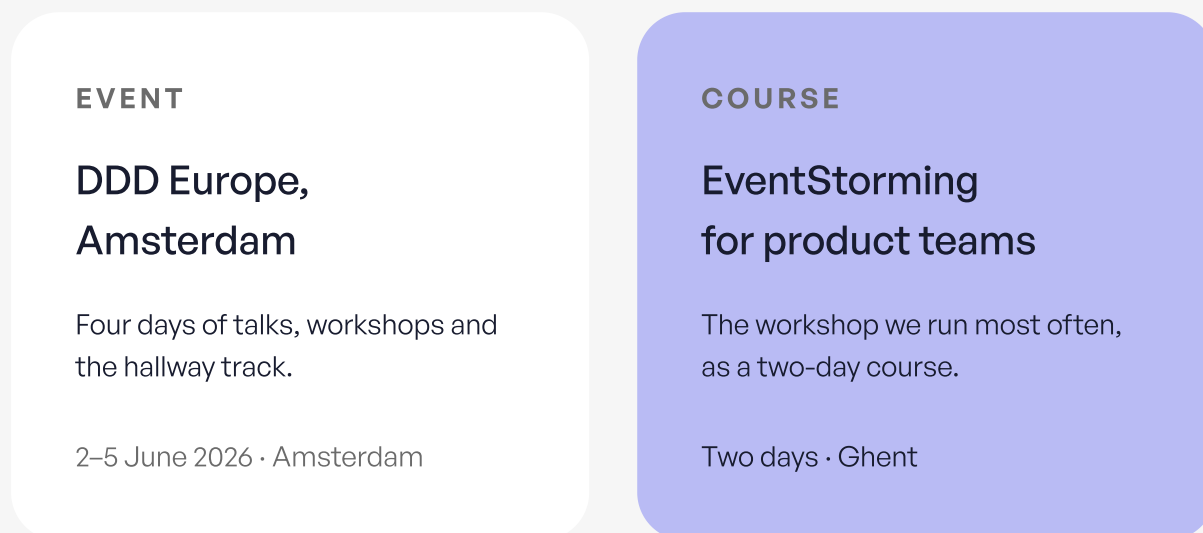
Eyebrow, heading, standfirst, actions — `--space-2`, `--space-3` and `--space-4` between them, in that order at every width. On a pastel the eyebrow is Night Blue like everything else: no grey is approved on any pastel.

Hero	Where	Top	Bottom
Page	Home, a landing page, the top of an index	<code>--space-8</code> , <code>--space-12</code> from 960px	the same
Detail	An article, an event, a course, a person	<code>--space-8</code> , <code>--space-18</code> from 960px	<code>--space-8</code> , <code>--space-12</code> from 960px
Cover	A title card, event artwork, a social image	One heading on a gradient, and nothing else on the artwork.	

The heading never sits on artwork. Photographs and illustrations are ruled out on page 29; the gradient licence on page 24 is for the body face at h3 or larger, and a hero's h1 is the page's Voyage setting — so the two never meet. Artwork sits beside the text, or below it.

A card is one of several

A course, an event, a case, an article. A single thing that happens to have a border is a panel, and does not need to look like a card.



The same card on two grounds. On the left the metadata is `--text-secondary`; on the right it is Night Blue at `--font-size-small`, because **no grey is approved on any pastel**. If a card needs grey, it is a `--surface-raised` card: choose the ground from what the card carries, not the other way round.

Part	Setting
Card	<code>--surface-raised</code> , <code>--radius-md</code> , <code>--space-4</code> padding, <code>--shadow-raised</code> . No border. A pastel card carries no shadow at all.
Media	Full bleed to the card's edge, a declared aspect ratio of 3:2, object-fit: cover .
Eyebrow	<code>--font-size-small</code> , uppercase, 0.12em, semibold.
Title	General Sans at <code>--font-weight-heading</code> , <code>--font-size-h5</code> . Never Voyage.
Body	<code>--font-size-body</code> . Three lines is plenty.
Metadata	<code>--font-size-small</code> , at the foot, pushed down so a row of cards lines up.

A card title is never Voyage: the display face is spent once on a page, and cards arrive in threes and fours. **A linked card does not move.** The whole card is the hit area, hover brings the title's underline from `--link-underline` to full colour, and focus rings the card rather than the title — there is no approved hover ground for a card, and page 33 rules out movement.

Violet is the callout

A passage that has to be read differently from the one above it. Two shapes, and the difference between them is width: a panel interrupts a column, a band spans the page.

This assumes a running system

Everything below describes work on software that is already in production. For a system that does not exist yet, start at the beginning instead.

Violet, `--radius-md`, `--space-4`, and no wider than the column it interrupts. Night Blue on Violet is 9.21. Yellow and Pink are section grounds and cards; the callout is Violet, which is what page 7 already says.

Shape	Setting
Panel	Inline in a column. <code>--radius-md</code> , <code>--space-4</code> padding, no elevation. An optional icon at <code>--icon-lg</code> , <code>--space-1</code> from its label.
Band	Full bleed. Violet, Yellow or Pink, or Night Blue under <code>data-surface="dark"</code> . Vertical padding <code>--space-6</code> , <code>--space-10</code> from 720px, <code>--space-12</code> from 960px. No radius.

A pastel on a dark page declares itself light

A callout on a dark ground carries `data-surface="light"`, and it is not optional: the pastels are the same colour in both themes, so what sits on them has to be too. Without the attribute the focus ring inside the callout inherits Snow White and measures 1.69 against the Violet. The mechanism is on page 33.

No grey inside a callout — so no fine print, no caption and no metadata; one that needs fine print is too long to be a callout. **One at a time:** two callouts in a row are a list, and should be set as one. **Never two coloured bands touching:** put a page-ground section between them, or neither one is emphasis any more.

Every quotation opens the same way

Someone's own words, set apart from the text around them — not a caveat or a warning, which is the callout on the previous page. Inline sits on `--surface-page`; the card is the one the cards page specifies.

INLINE — IN A COLUMN OF RUNNING PROSE



The model stopped being what we argued about in meetings and became what the code was named after.

Ineke Vandersteen Head of Engineering, Meridian Bank

CARD — A TESTIMONIAL, WHERE THE FULLER ATTRIBUTION BELONGS



Three days in, we had a name for it.



Tomas Ruiz

Product Lead, Northbeam



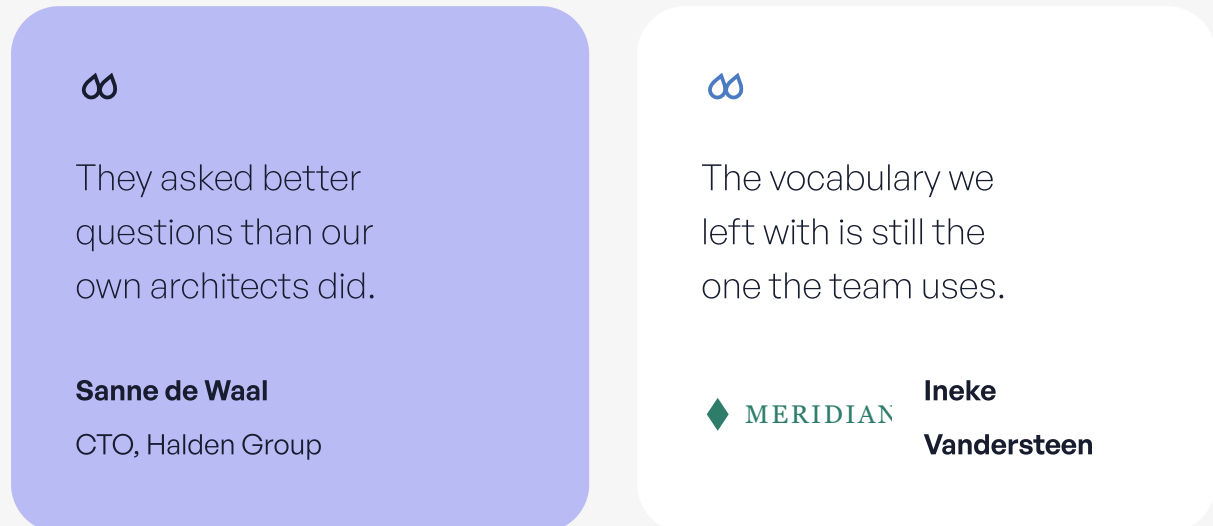
We stopped translating between the spreadsheet and the system.

Aoife Brennan

A full attribution beside one with nothing but a name — the parts are independent toggles, though the mark and the text never vary. **The avatar is a placeholder.**

Part	Setting
Quote mark	<code>quote.svg</code> , <code>--icon-lg</code> , <code>--colour-ocean-blue</code> . Never optional.
Quote text	General Sans, <code>--font-weight-light</code> , <code>--font-size-h6</code> , balanced — that step at every width.
Attribution	Name semibold; role and company <code>--text-secondary</code> , joined with ", " or to a bare name with " · ". Set off by weight and colour, never size. Company drops when a logo is present.

Ocean Blue, except on a pastel



On a pastel the mark and the rule are Night Blue. Page 7 approves Ocean Blue on white, Snow White and Night Blue only; the pastels take Night Blue as their one foreground, and a blockquote is no exception to what a card on a pastel already applies to everything in it. On the right, **the typed company name is dropped because the logo is present.**

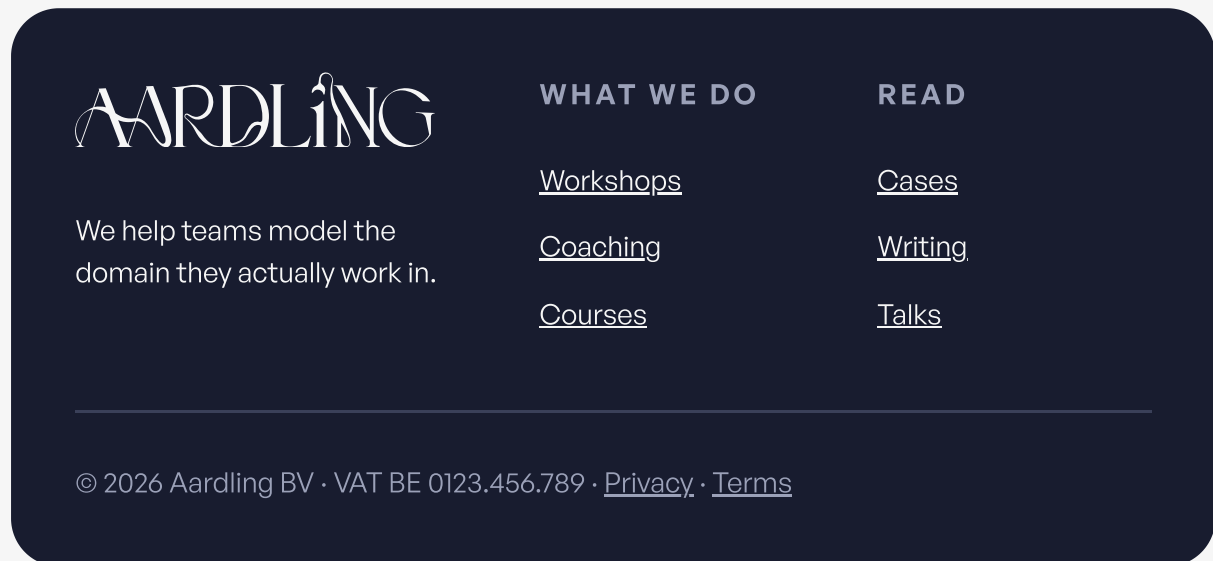
Part	Setting
Photo	Square, --radius-sm , object-fit: cover , at --control-height-sm — 44px, the box an icon button uses. A 1px --border-hairline outlines it, always. Never a circle: page 33 withdrew the decorative circle family.
Company logo	The company's own mark, never recoloured , at --icon-lg height with the width following. Always an accessible name, alt="Meridian" . Ask for a variant that reads on a dark ground if the page might show one.
Width	Full is the default — the measure of its column, no wider, as the callout panel takes. Half suits a shorter quote: centred, breaking the paragraph either side rather than floating, and dropping to full below --breakpoint-sm .

A testimonial card needs no half-width rule of its own: two cards side by side is already half width, one spanning the row already full. **At 360px**, check the quote wraps to no more than four or five lines before the citation feels distant from what it cites, and that protected terms hold whole in a single **nowrap** span.

The footer declares its own ground

One footer, on every page, and one attribute does the whole job:

`<footer data-surface="dark">`. It sets all ten roles to their dark values, so the footer is the same in both themes and nothing inside it hand-sets a colour.



Order	Setting
1 · 2	The logotype, then one sentence saying what Aardling does — two lines at most. <code>--space-4</code> between them.
3	The newsletter signup. A slot: its field, its label and its validation belong to the forms, not here.
4	Link groups, in columns from 720px at the grid gutter.
5 · 6	A <code>--border-hairline</code> rule, then the legal line in <code>--text-secondary</code> — 6.57 on Night Blue.

The logotype is the master inlined and given `color: var(--text-primary)`: it is drawn in `currentColor`, so it needs no separate file, and a lockup is for places that cannot set a colour. Not below 96px wide — the floor on page 21 — and 160px to 200px is comfortable. **Every link is at least 44px high**, set as a minimum rather than computed: an 18px link at 1.5 line height with `--space-1` above and below measures 43px, which is near enough to be wrong. **No dark section directly above the footer** — two dark regions meeting make one long region with an invisible seam.

We, not I, and never an institution

Aardling is a group of consultants, and the writing says so. Not "I" — that belongs to a personal blog. Not "Aardling provides", which turns a room full of people into an institution issuing statements. Name the people where naming them helps: "Gien ran the EventStorming session" beats "a consultant facilitated the session".

Register

Expert, plain, unhurried. Our readers are tech leaders in finance, logistics, government, media and biotech. Much of what we write gets forwarded to someone who controls a budget; write so that both can read it.

British English

Not just the spelling — modelling, organisation, analyse, recognise, prioritise, licence as a noun — but the vocabulary that goes with it.

Proper nouns split two ways

Places take their English name, where one exists. Antwerp, not Antwerpen. Brussels, The Hague, Cologne. Most places have no English name and are left as they are: Hoorn, Lille. Never invent one.

Companies and people keep their own spelling. Never anglicised, never stripped of accents. Société Générale, not Societe Generale.

Say what the work is. We run workshops, model domains, review architectures, teach courses, and sit with teams for weeks. Every one of those happened on a date. Prefer it to the category it belongs to.

Our vocabulary, without assuming the reader shares it

Domain-Driven Design, EventStorming, Event Sourcing, bounded contexts, Team Topologies — our terms, used without apology. But the reader may not share our background, so a term earns its place by being either explained in passing or unnecessary. Nothing that assumes the reader was in the room.

YES

We mapped the bounded contexts — the boundaries inside which a model holds — and found three places where two teams owned the same concept.

NO

We applied strategic DDD to surface context boundary misalignment.

No hype

Not exciting, not revolutionary, not game-changing, not a journey, not future-proof. If a sentence would survive being pasted into any other consultancy's website, it is not about us.

NO

In a world full of concrete, Aardling is the tree that grows with you.

YES

We help you make sense of complex environments. Through models, we guide your software design strategy and untangle organisational constraints.

The original brand guide carries a manifesto and four values written in a register this brand rejects. Their substance is kept; the register is not.

Active, short, and backed

No unbacked claims

No superlatives, no numbers without a source, no promises nobody has thought through. "We trained about 800 engineers at Shopify" is a fact with a case study behind it. "The go-to technology consultants" is not a fact at all.

No filler

If a sentence can be deleted and nothing is lost, delete it. No throat-clearing before the point, no restating what was just said in different words.

Sentences

Active voice. Short sentences. A verb where a nominalisation tempts.

NO

Comprehensive delivery of transformational value is provided across the engagement.

YES

We work with your team for three days and leave you with a model you can use.

THE ONE APPROVED TAGLINE

Software strategy, architecture, and domain modelling in complex environments.

Use it verbatim, or do not use one. It carries a serial comma. That is the approved wording and it is not corrected to house style, here or anywhere it is reproduced.

The package is the source of truth

Generated from [@aardling/brand-aardling](#) at version 1.0.0-beta.3. Where this printed page condenses, the file in the package is the longer answer.

Path	Contents
tokens/	Design tokens as data, and the same tokens as CSS custom properties.
guidelines/colour.md	The palette, the accepted pairs, and what each is for.
guidelines/typography.md	The two faces, the scale, and the weights.
guidelines/layout.md	Spacing, radii, and the protected terms.
guidelines/web.md	Breakpoints, states, dark mode, motion, elevation, icon sizing.
guidelines/imagery.md	Gradients and illustrations, and what may sit on them.
guidelines/logos.md	Masters, lockups, clear space, minimum sizes.
guidelines/naming.md	The brand name and the company names.
guidelines/voice.md	Register, person, and do/don't examples.
assets/logos/	The logotype and the icon logo, both SVG, both currentColor.
assets/logos/lockups/	22 flattened mark-on-ground files, generated from the masters.
assets/icons/	The 50-mark interface set, SVG, currentColor.
assets/favicons/	The favicon source and its rasters.
assets/fonts/	Both faces as woff2, plus the @font-face declarations.
assets/images/	Four gradients, and three illustrations.
skills/aardling-brand/	A skill teaching agents to apply this brand.